Arsenic and Old Lace

By Joseph Kesselring

ABBY: **(Pg 6-7)** My sister Martha and I have been talking about your sermon last Sunday. Living here next to the church all our lives, we've seen so many ministers come and go**.** [And now] with the war trouble, I've almost come to the conclusion that this Mr. Hitler isn't a Christian.

MINISTER HARPER: I must admit, Miss Abby, that war and violence seem far removed from these surroundings.

ABBY: It is peaceful here, isn't it?

MINISTER HARPER: Yes – peaceful. The gentle virtues that went out with candlelight and good manners.

TEDDY: **(Pg 12)** *(Enters the room with sweeping strides)* CHARGE! *(blows his bugle)* Charge the blockhouse!

ABBY: **(Pg 7)** Teddy, your brother Mortimer will be here a little later.

TEDDY: *(baring his teeth in a broad grin)* Dee-lighted! *(exits with another bugle blow)*

MINISTER HARPER: **(Pg 12)** Have you ever tried to persuade him that he wasn't Teddy Roosevelt?

MARTHA: He's so happy being Teddy . . .

ABBY: Once, a long time ago, we thought if he would be George Washington, it might be a change for him.

MARTHA: But he stayed under his bed for days and just wouldn't be ***anybody***.

ABBY: And we'd so much rather he'd be Mr. Roosevelt than nobody. *(to Martha)* Martha, dear, Dr. Harper has made all arrangements for Teddy to go to Happy Dale Sanitarium after we pass on **(Pg 13)** and arranged for Mr. Witherspoon.

MINISTER HARPER: He's the Superintendent of Happy Dale . . .

ABBY: To drop in tomorrow to meet Teddy.

TEDDY: *(racing into the room again)* That's bully! Just bully!

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INTRODUCTION

Martha and Abby; two elderly sisters. The epitome of grace, community service and decorum. After all they've cared for their delusional nephew Teddy for years now, and what is more commendable than that?

Enter Mortimer Brewster, another nephew, who uncovers the true extent of Martha and Abby's community service -- helping lonely, unhappy men find peace with a little glass of elderberry wine.

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MORTIMER: **(Pg 15)** *(Mortimer Brewster enters)* Hello, Aunt Martha, Aunt Abby (Air kisses)

TEDDY: **(Pg 18)** Hello, Mortimer!

MORTIMER: *(gravely with a salute)* How are you, Mr. President?

TEDDY: Bully; thank you. Just bully! What news have you brought me?

MORTIMER: Just this, Mr. President, the country is squarely behind you.

TEDDY: *(beaming)* Yes, I know. Isn't it wonderful? *(beat)* Well, good-bye. [I'm off to] Panama! *(He exits to cellar)*

MARTHA: **(Pg 41)** We let him dig the Panama Canal in the cellar.

MORTIMER: **(Pg 18)** *(knowingly)* Panama's the cellar. *(he crosses to the desk and looks through drawers as he speaks to the aunts)* **(Pg 20)** By the way, I left one of the chapters of my book on Thoreau here. Now where could I have put that?

ABBY: **(Pg 21)** *(turned away, arranging the afternoon's tea service)* I do hope the play tonight will be something you can enjoy for once. What's the name of it?

MORTIMER: "Murder Will Out." *(he continues searching as he speaks)* When the curtain goes up the first thing you'll see will be a dead body! *(he lifts the window-seat and sees a dead body; not believing it, he drops window-seat then throws it open and stares in. In a strained voice)* Aunt Abby!?

ABBY: *(at sideboard)* Yes, dear?

MORTIMER: You were going to make plans for Teddy to go to that . . . sanitarium . . .Happy Dale?

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ABBY: Yes, dear, it's all arranged. Dr. Harper was here today and brought the papers. Here they are. *(He takes them from her)*

MORTIMER: Teddy's got to go to Happy Dale now. Tonight!

MARTHA: *(enters with table settings)* There's no such hurry as that.

ABBY: **(Pg 22-23)** No. When Teddy starts working on the canal you can't get his mind on anything else.

MORTIMER: Right away, I tell you! Right away!

ABBY: *(turning to Mortimer)* Why, Mortimer, how can you say such a thing?

MORTIMER: *(Trying to be calm)* Listen, darlings, I'm sorry, but I've got some shocking news for you. You know we've humored Teddy because we thought he was harmless.

MARTHA: Why he is harmless!

MORTIMER: He **was** harmless. You've got to know sometime. It might as well be now, Teddy's killed a man! He has to be confined. *(he points to window seat)* There's a body in the window-seat!

ABBY: Yes, dear, we know.

MORTIMER: You know?

MARTHA: Of course, dear, but it has nothing to do with Teddy.

MORTIMER: But who is he?

ABBY: His name's Hoskins. Adam Hoskins. That's really all I know about him -- except he's a Methodist.

MORTIMER: Well, what's he doing here? What happened to him?

MARTHA: He died.

MORTIMER: Aunt Martha, men don't just get into window seats and die.

ABBY: [Silly boy] No, he died first.

MORTIMER: Well, how?

ABBY: Oh, Mortimer. The gentleman died because he drank some wine with poison in it.

MORTIMER: How did the poison get in the wine?

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MARTHA: Well, we put it in wine because it's less noticeable. When it's in tea it has a distinct odor.

MORTIMER: You put it in the wine?

ABBY: Yes. And I put Mr. Hoskins in the window-seat because Dr. Harper was coming.

MORTIMER: So, you knew what you'd done! You didn't want Dr. Harper to see the body!

ABBY: Well, not at tea -- that wouldn't have been very nice. *(Mortimer is speechless)*

MARTHA: **(Pg 24-25)** Dear, stop being so excited.

ABBY: And for pity's sake stop worrying. We told you to forget the whole thing.

MORTIMER: Well, you can't leave him there.

MARTHA: We don't intend to, dear.

ABBY: No, Teddy's down in the cellar now digging.

MORTIMER: You're going to bury Mr. Hotchkiss in the cellar?

MARTHA: Yes, dear, that's what we did with the others.

MORTIMER: Others? More than one others?

MARTHA: Oh, yes, dear. Let me see, this is eleven. Isn't it, Abby?

ABBY: No, dear, this makes twelve. Well, anyway, they're all down in the cellar.

MORTIMER: *(floored)* Who was the first one?

ABBY: Mr. Midgely. He was a Baptist.

MARTHA: Of course, I still think we can't claim full credit for him because he just died.

ABBY: Martha means without any help from us. You see, Mr. Midgely came here looking for a room . . .

MARTHA: **(Pg 26-27)** He was such a lonely old man. . .

ABBY: All his kin were dead and it left him so forlorn and unhappy -- And then when his heart attack came -- and he sat dead in that chair *(Pointing)* looking so peaceful, we made up our minds then and there that if we could help other lonely old men to that same peace, we would!

MARTHA: *(giggling)*Teddy had been digging in Panama and he thought Mr. Midgely was a Yellow Fever victim.

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ABBY: That meant he had to be buried immediately.

MARTHA: So, we all took him down to Panama and put him in the lock.

MORTIMER: And that's how all this started -- that man walking in here and dropping dead.

ABBY: Of course, we realized we couldn't depend on that happening again. So . . .

MARTHA: You remember those jars of poison that have been up on the shelves in Grandfather's laboratory? Well, dear, for a gallon of elderberry wine I take one teaspoonful of arsenic, then add a half teaspoonful of strychnine and then just a pinch of cyanide.

MORTIMER: Should have quite a kick.

ABBY: Yes! As a matter of fact, one of our gentlemen found time to say "How delicious!"

MORTIMER: **(Pg 31)** *(sputtering)* You can't do things like that! It's not only against the law. It's wrong! It's not a nice thing to do.

ABBY: Mortimer, we don't try to stop you from doing thing you like to do. I don't see why you should interfere with us.

TEDDY: **(Pg 39)** *(enters from cellar, blows a terrific blast on his bugle)* CHARGE!

ABBY: **(Pg 45-46)** Teddy! Teddy, there's been another Yellow Fever victim. *(with a finger to her lips)* We must keep it a secret.

TEDDY: A state secret? *(he's excited)* You have the word of the President of the United States *(crosses his heart)*

ABBY: Go back down in the cellar and when it's all dark, you come up and take the poor man down to the Canal.

MARTHA: And we'll come down later and hold services.

TEDDY: Where is the poor devil?

MARTHA: He's in the window seat.

TEDDY: It seems to be spreading. We've never had Yellow Fever there before. *(blows his bugle and exits)*

******* [Spoken Transition: The next day after reports of horrendous bugle blowing from the neighbors, police officer Rooney arrives at the Brewster residence] ******

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MORTIMER: *(a knock; Mortimer answers the door)* **(Pg 84)** Captain, I'm Mortimer Brewster.

TEDDY: **(Pg 83)** *(butting in)* There are bodies in the cellar.

ROONEY: Who are you?

TEDDY: I'm President Roosevelt

MORTIMER: **(Pg 84)** My brother Teddy -- the one who blew the bugle.

ROONEY: *(to Teddy)* **(Pg 83)** Well, you've blown your last bugle. *(to Mortimer)* **(Pg 84)** He's got to be put away!

TEDDY: **(Pg 83)** *(interjecting)* All the bodies in the cellar are Yellow Fever victims.

MORTIMER: **(Pg 84)** I quite agree with you. In fact, it's all arranged for.

ROONEY: Where's he going?

MORTIMER: Happy Dale.

ROONEY: All right, I don't care where he goes as long as he goes!

MORTIMER: Oh, he's going all right. But I want you to know that everything that's happened around here Teddy's responsible for. Now, those bodies in the cellar . . .

ROONEY: *(thinks this is a joke)* Yeah, yeah, those bodies in the cellar! It ain't enough his disturbing the peace with that bugle, but can you imagine what would happen if that cock-eyed story about bodies in the cellar got around? And now he's starting a Yellow Fever scare. *(shakes his head and chuckles)*

MORTIMER: *(Greatly relieved, with an embarrassed laugh)* Bodies. Do you think anybody would believe that story? *(a knock the door)*

MORTIMER: Will you excuse me? *(He goes to door and admits Elaine and Mr. Witherspoon, an elderly, tight-lipped disciplinarian)*

ELAINE: **(Pg 85)** This is Mr. Witherspoon, the superintendent of Happy Dale. He's come to meet Teddy.

ROONEY: *(introducing himself)* Lieutenant Rooney. I'm glad you're here, because you're taking him back with you today!

WITHERSPOON: Today? I had no idea it was this immediate.

ROONEY: The papers are all signed, he goes today! There's your man! *(pointing at Teddy)*

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TEDDY: *(livid)* Complete insubordination! You men will find out I'm no mollycoddle. When the President of the United States is treated like that -- what's this country coming to?

MORTIMER: *(trying to calm things down, he speaks to Teddy as to a child)* Mr. President, I have very good news for you. Your term of office is over.

TEDDY: *(thinking)* OH! Now I go on my hunting trip to Africa! Well, I must get started immediately. *(he looks at Witherspoon suspiciously)* Is he trying to move into the White House before I've moved out?

MORTIMER: Who, Teddy?

TEDDY: *(pointing at Witherspoon)* Taft!

MORTIMER: This isn't Mr. Taft, Teddy. This is Mr. Witherspoon. *(enthusiastically)* He's to be your guide in Africa.

TEDDY: *(Shakes hands with Witherspoon)* **(Pg 86)** Bully! Bully! *(he turns to the Aunts)* Good-bye, Aunt Abby . . . Aunt Martha. I'm on my way to Africa – isn't it wonderful? CHARGE! *(Teddy and Mortimer exit upstairs and Rooney exits outside to wait)*

ABBY: **(Pg 93)** Mr. Witherspoon? Does your family live with you at Happy Dale?

WITHERSPOON: I have no family.

MARTHA: Well, I suppose you consider everyone at Happy Dale your family?

WITHERSPOON: As head of the institution, I have to keep quite aloof.

ABBY: That must make it very lonely for you. *(with a knowing nod to Martha)* Well, Martha, I think we should at least offer Mr. Witherspoon a glass of elderberry wine.

MARTHA: *(pouring a glass)* We make it ourselves.

WITHERSPOON: Why, yes . . . You don't see much elderberry wine nowadays. *(He takes the glass and toasts the ladies; then keels over)*

TEDDY: *(off stage)* **(Pg 85)** CHARGE! *(Bugle blast)*

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